

Degrees of the scale

The notes of the major and minor scales are given names and roman numerals to help identify their positions in relation to the keynote, or tonic. These are called degrees of the scale.

SEE ALSO

◀ 60–61 Major scales

◀ 62–63 Minor scales

◀ 64–67 Keys

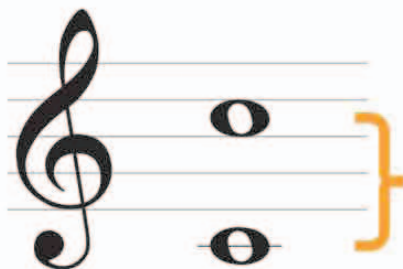
◀ 74–75 Modulation

Chord types

130–131 ▶

The keynote

The note the scale starts and ends on is known as the keynote of the scale. In degrees of the scale, this note is called the tonic and is given the Roman numeral I. It does not matter whether it is the starting note or the top note of the scale, both notes are identified in the same way.



◁ The tonic

In a C major scale, the keynote is both Middle C and the C one octave above it. These notes are labeled I and are called the tonic.

Keynote = I = Tonic

Naming degrees of the scale

In an ascending major or harmonic minor scale spanning one octave, the degrees of the scale are tonic, supertonic, mediant, subdominant, dominant, submediant, leading note, and tonic again. Degrees of the scale are also used to identify keys. For example, when C major is the tonic key, the dominant key is G major because its keynote, G, is the fifth note, or dominant degree, of the C major scale.

▽ Up the scale

The chart below shows the eight notes of an ascending major or harmonic minor scale, and the Roman numeral and degree of the scale that identifies each note.

